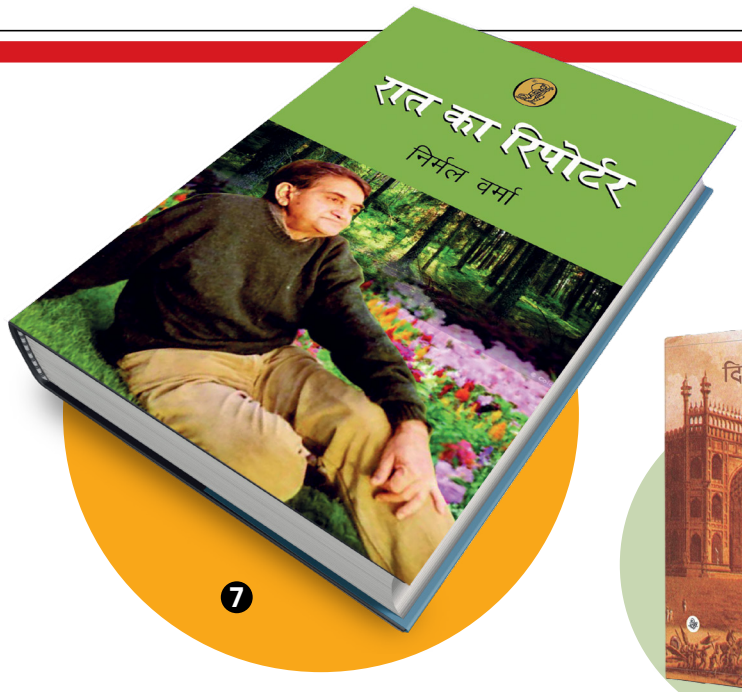
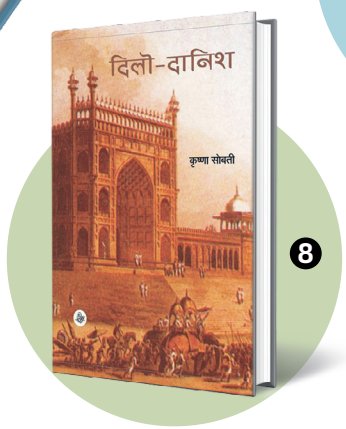
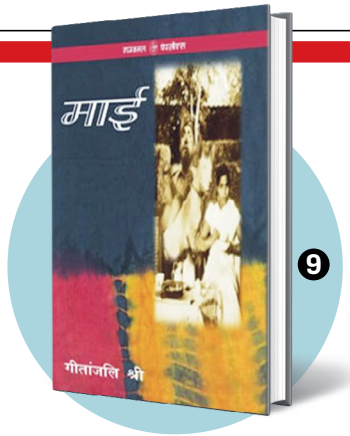
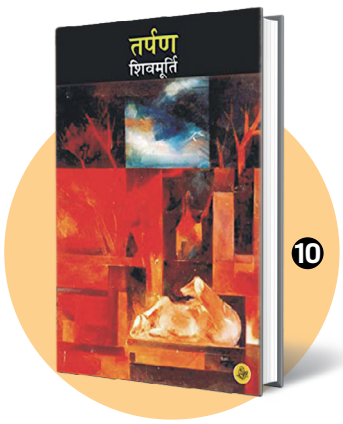








It is in relation to this pervasive disenchantment that I understand the somewhat puzzling visibility of Vinod Kumar Shukla's *Naukar ki Kameez* (1979). The innocent pointlessness that informs his low-key narratives of the mundane trivialities of small-town life—neither the raucous metropolis nor the seething village—captures, in some sense, the mood of the 'less deceived': the generations that were never enchanted enough by the colourful promises of independence, democracy and even that strange, forgotten thing, socialism, to feel disenchanted, let alone angry. Perhaps its mysterious attraction lies in the fact that Shukla's writing appears like an understated disavowal of the gravitational pull of Significance that, for better and for worse, hobbles all who seek to engage with Indian realities.

Of course, there is anger out there—many kinds of anger—lapping at the edges of our possible futures. But while it has found copious expression in poetry—as was seen during the anti-CAA movement—its expression in fiction is relatively limited. Caste is, as so often in India, the obvious place to look. The matter of Premchand's representation of Dalit experience, in several classic short stories—*Kafan* and *Sadgati* and *Thakur ka Kuan*—is too complex to be tackled parenthetically. Still, it is an indication of some fundamental aesthetic struggle that some of the most powerful representations of Dalit experience are to be found in texts that are, alas, all-too-unfictional. I am thinking of Om Prakash Balmiki's *Joothan* (1997), and another that deserves to be much better known—Tulsi Ram's *Murdahiya* (2010). Although I invoke its name in the context of anger, what is remarkable about *Murdahiya* is that its unsparing account of a Dalit childhood is enlivened by moments of happiness and laughter that must find expression even in the direst circumstances. Indeed, it is this that gives the informing anger its unforgettable edge. Another writer whom I have encountered only recently is Shivmurti. A career civil servant, Shivmurti does not wear his caste identity on his sleeve, but it is precisely his inwardness with that range of experience—all-around-us and yet, strangely invisible—that gives his novels and short stories their air of authenticity, their disenchanted contemporaneity. Read the stories in *Kesar Kasturi* (2007) or the novel *Tarpan* (2010).

THE UNSPARING ACCOUNT OF DALIT CHILDHOOD IN *MURDAHIYA* IS ENLIVENED BY LAUGHTER TOO

One can hardly write an account of the Hindi novel today without mentioning Geetanjali Shree. Her *Ret Samadhi* (2018), reincarnated as *Tomb of Sand*, is hogging all the attention, but her first work, *Mai* (2001), is a much-acclaimed account of everyday patriarchy closely observed in a domestic context. It is significant also as the quiet but impassioned starting point of a remarkable trajectory. Shree has been consistently experimental, and her *Hamara Shehar Uss Baras* (1998), written in the aftermath of the Demolition, is a stylish take on the local stirrings of the toxicity in which we are drowning.

The missing Hamlet in this short essay on post-1947 Hindi novels is, of course, Nirmal Verma. And since my account is organised around the need and desire to escape from Premchand, perhaps it would be fair to note that the surest way of doing so is, perhaps, to escape from India altogether. Thus, Verma's first novel, *Ve Din* (1964), is set in Prague. However, in his 'Emergency' novel, *Raat ka Reporter* (1989), Verma came close to engaging with what E.M. Forster described as the world of "telegrams and anger", as against the "personal relations that are the important thing for ever and ever". ■